

Haligric Research Integration Series

THE CHRISTIAN DENOMINATIONS

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

What Makes Each Branch Distinct - From Roman Catholic to Pentecostal, From Mormon to Seventh-day Adventist, From the Oldest Institutional Church to the Newest Megachurch

One teaching. Two thousand years. Over 50,000 denominations.

Each claiming to represent the teaching of a first-century Jewish peasant who never wrote anything down.

This document does not take sides. It maps them.

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Introduction - One Tree, Many Branches

One Teaching. Two Thousand Years. Over 50,000 Denominations. There are estimated to be over 50,000 distinct Christian denominations in the world today, each claiming authority to represent the teaching of a first-century Jewish peasant who never wrote anything down. This document does not take sides in the theological disputes between them. It maps them - accurately, fairly, and through the Haligric lens that asks of every tradition the same question: where does this teaching locate divine authority, and does it point that authority inward toward the practitioner's own direct experience, or outward toward an external source?

The answer, across virtually every branch covered here, is the same: outward. The variations are in where outward points - to the Pope, to the Bible, to the charismatic preacher, to the correct doctrinal formula, to the organization. The exceptions - the mystics, the Quakers, certain strands of Pentecostal direct experience - are the places where something more interesting happens. Those exceptions are noted.

Christianity today has approximately 2.6 billion adherents worldwide - the largest religious grouping on earth. Its center of gravity has shifted dramatically: in 2025, an estimated 69% of all Christians live in the Global South (Africa, Asia, Latin America), compared to a Europe-and-North-America-dominated faith just a century ago. The fastest-growing expressions of Christianity are Pentecostal and Charismatic movements, now numbering over 650 million globally and projected to reach one billion by 2050.

Roman Catholic - The Original Institution

Founded: 1st century CE (as formal institution from 4th century) | Members: ~1.27 billion | HQ: Vatican City

Roman Catholicism is the largest single Christian denomination and the direct institutional descendant of the church that emerged from the Council of Nicaea in 325 CE. On May 8, 2025, following the death of Pope Francis on April 21, 2025, Cardinal Robert Francis Prevost - a Chicago-born Augustinian friar who had spent much of his ministry in Peru - was elected the 267th Bishop of Rome, taking the name Pope Leo XIV. He is the first pope ever born in the United States, the first from the Order of Saint Augustine, and a dual citizen of the U.S. and Peru. He chose the name Leo XIV to echo Pope Leo XIII, whose 1891 encyclical *Rerum Novarum* established modern Catholic social teaching on workers' rights, signaling that his papacy would engage the challenges of artificial intelligence and a new industrial revolution.

Papal infallibility - the teaching that the Pope, when speaking formally on matters of faith and morals, cannot err - was defined as doctrine only in 1870 at the First Vatican Council. It has been formally invoked only twice since. The seven sacraments - Baptism, Confirmation, Eucharist, Penance, Anointing of the Sick, Holy Orders, and Matrimony - are the primary mechanisms of divine grace in Catholic theology. The Eucharist is the central sacrament: the bread and wine literally become the body and blood of Jesus Christ through the process of transubstantiation - not symbolically, but actually. The Mass re-presents the sacrifice of Calvary in an unbloody manner.

The veneration of Mary and the saints - prayer directed to Mary and to canonized holy persons as intercessors before God - is one of the most distinctive Catholic practices. Mary's specific titles (Theotokos - God-bearer, Co-Redemptrix in some theological currents, Queen of Heaven) preserve a feminine divine presence in Catholic life that is found nowhere else in mainstream Western Christianity. The rosary, the Marian apparitions (Lourdes, Fatima, Guadalupe), and the extraordinary global devotion to Mary suggest that the feminine divine, formally excluded from the theology of the Trinity, found her way back through the door of Marian devotion.

EARLY PAPACY OF LEO XIV: In his first year, Pope Leo XIV has pursued a papacy defined by global diplomacy, the consistent life ethic, and advocacy for marginalized populations. His first papal encyclical, Magnifica Humanitas (Magnificent Humanity), addressed the ethics of artificial intelligence, warning against AI deployment in automated warfare and its potential to exacerbate economic inequality and labor displacement. In May 2026, he made a historic apology for the Vatican role in legitimizing slavery. He has condemned the 2026 Iran war and called for peace, which generated a direct public attack from President Trump, who called him weak on crime. He has continued Pope Francis policy of appointing women to senior Vatican roles - including to the Dicastery for Bishops - and has advanced ecumenical dialogue with Eastern Orthodoxy, including meetings with Patriarch Bartholomew I aimed at eventual full communion between Rome and Constantinople.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Catholic Church is the most complete institutional preservation of pre-Christian Roman religious ritual in the world - Latin, incense, vestments, processional, the liturgical calendar of festivals, the sacred meal, the priestly caste. What Rome absorbed from the indigenous religions it conquered, it preserved inside Christianity. The Haligric practitioner sees both the suppression and the preservation operating simultaneously.

Eastern Orthodox - The Oldest Continuous Christianity

Founded: 1st century CE (Great Schism from Rome: 1054 CE) | Members: ~260 million | Centers: Constantinople, Moscow, Alexandria

Eastern Orthodoxy predates the Catholic-Protestant split by 500 years and understands itself as the original and unchanged Christianity. The Great Schism of 1054 CE formally separated East from West over theological disputes (including the filioque - whether the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father alone or from both Father and Son) and jurisdictional disputes over whether the Pope of Rome had universal authority or was merely first among equals.

The theological distinction that makes Orthodoxy the most mystically sophisticated branch of mainstream Christianity is theosis - the teaching that the purpose of human life is not merely forgiveness or moral improvement but actual deification: the human being's progressive transformation into the divine likeness, participating in the divine nature itself. Saint Athanasius's statement - "God became human so that humans might become God" - is taken with full theological seriousness. This is not metaphor. It is the goal.

Orthodox worship is the most complete sensory sacred experience in Christian tradition - the Divine Liturgy (attributed to Saint John Chrysostom) is a two-thousand-year-old ceremony of extraordinary beauty involving chanting, incense, candlelight, iconography, and the progressive movement of the congregation through the drama of creation, fall, and redemption. The icon - the sacred image of Christ, Mary, or the saints - is not a painting but a window into the divine realm, venerated (not worshipped) as a point of contact with the sacred person depicted.

HALIGRIC LENS: Theosis - the teaching that the human being can become divine through participation in the divine energies - is the closest any mainstream Christian tradition has come to the Haligric understanding that the divine lives as the human being. Orthodox mystics like Gregory Palamas and Symeon the New Theologian described experiences of divine light indistinguishable from what Sufi masters, Buddhist meditators, and Hindu yogis describe. The recognition is the same. The vocabulary differs.

Lutheran - The Reformation Begins

Founded: 1517 CE (Martin Luther's Ninety-Five Theses) | Members: ~75 million worldwide

On October 31, 1517, a German Augustinian friar named Martin Luther nailed - or possibly posted - a document containing ninety-five theses for academic debate to the door of the Castle Church in Wittenberg. What Luther intended as an academic disputation became the spark that permanently fractured Western Christianity. Luther's central theological insight - developed from his intensive study of Paul's letter to the Romans - was that salvation is by faith alone (*sola fide*), not by works, not by purchase of indulgences, not by institutional sacramental participation. This discovery, which Luther described as a "gateway to paradise," made the entire sacramental system of the Catholic Church theologically unnecessary.

Luther's second principle - *sola scriptura*, scripture alone - removed the Pope's authority as the final interpreter of Christian truth and placed that authority in the biblical text, accessible to any literate person. He translated the Bible into German specifically so that ordinary people could read it for themselves. This was a genuine democratization of religious authority - the first major crack in the wall of institutional mediation - though Luther did not follow its logic to the conclusion that every person's direct interpretation was equally valid.

HALIGRIC LENS: The priesthood of all believers - Luther's teaching that every Christian has direct access to God without institutional mediation - is the most Haligric statement in the Reformation. Luther went to the door of direct access and opened it a crack. He then tried to close it again by insisting on the authority of his specific interpretation of scripture. The door he opened has never fully closed.

Calvinist / Reformed - Predestination and the Protestant Work Ethic

Founded: 1536 CE (John Calvin, Geneva) | Members: ~80 million (Reformed churches globally)

John Calvin was a French theologian who made Geneva, Switzerland into a model Protestant city in the mid-sixteenth century. His most controversial doctrine: predestination. Calvin argued, from Paul and from Augustine, that God - being omniscient and omnipotent - has determined from eternity who will be saved (the elect) and who will be damned (the reprobate). This determination is not based on God's foreknowledge of the individual's choices but on God's sovereign will alone. Nothing the individual does can change it.

The psychological consequences were profound. Max Weber, in *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, argued that the anxiety produced by not knowing whether one was among the elect produced a compensatory drive toward worldly success - which was then read as a sign of election. The accumulation of wealth as evidence of divine favor is the theological root of the prosperity gospel that Joel Osteen preaches today, though the connection has been largely forgotten.

HALIGRIC LENS: Predestination is the logical endpoint of a theology that places all divine authority outside the human being - if God determines everything and the human being determines nothing, the human being is simply a passive recipient of a divine decision made before they were born. No Haligric tradition anywhere in the world operates from this framework. Every tradition in this library, without exception, teaches that the human being is a conscious participant in their own becoming.

Anglican / Episcopalian - The Church of England

Founded: 1534 CE (Henry VIII's Act of Supremacy) | Members: ~85 million (Anglican Communion globally)

The Church of England was not born from theological conviction. It was born from a divorce. When Pope Clement VII refused to annul Henry VIII's marriage to Catherine of Aragon -

partly because Catherine's nephew, the Holy Roman Emperor Charles V, had the Pope essentially under political control - Henry had Parliament pass the Act of Supremacy in 1534, declaring the English monarch the Supreme Head of the Church in England.

Archbishop Thomas Cranmer developed the Book of Common Prayer - first issued in 1549 - which gave English Christianity its characteristic liturgical language, resonant and poetic in a way that influenced English literature as profoundly as Shakespeare. The via media - the middle way between Catholic sacramentalism and Protestant doctrinal rigidity - became Anglicanism's theological identity. The Episcopal Church in the United States is the American branch, formed after the American Revolution. It has been one of the most theologically progressive major denominations in American Christianity - ordaining women as priests in 1976, ordaining openly gay bishops, and conducting same-sex marriages.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Anglican tradition's greatest contribution is its liturgical language - the Book of Common Prayer gave English speakers a vocabulary for the sacred that has shaped poetry, literature, and personal prayer for five centuries. The Haligric practitioner recognizes that beauty in sacred language is not decorative but functional - it opens the resonant body in a way that doctrinal propositions cannot.

Methodist - The Heart Strangely Warmed

Founded: 1739 CE (John Wesley, England) | Members: ~80 million worldwide

John Wesley was an Anglican priest who never intended to found a new denomination. In 1739, at a small meeting on Aldersgate Street in London, he had an experience he described in his journal: "I felt my heart strangely warmed. I felt I did trust in Christ, Christ alone for salvation; and an assurance was given me that He had taken away my sins, even mine." This direct personal experience of divine presence - not mediated by sacrament, not produced by correct doctrine, but felt as a warmth in the heart - became the model for Methodist spirituality. Wesley traveled 250,000 miles on horseback and preached 40,000 sermons across Britain and America.

Methodist theology emphasizes prevenient grace (God's grace available to everyone before any human response), free will (rejecting Calvinist predestination), social holiness (personal transformation expressed through social justice), and the possibility of entire sanctification - the Wesleyan teaching that the believer can, in this life, reach a state in which love of God and neighbor perfectly governs all action.

CONTEMPORARY: The United Methodist Church experienced its most significant schism since 1844 (over slavery) in 2022-2024. Approximately 7,600 US congregations - nearly a quarter of all American UMC churches - formally disaffiliated to form the Global Methodist Church, a conservative denomination that maintains bans on same-sex marriage and LGBTQ+ ordination. The 2024 General Conference then removed all anti-LGBTQ+ language from the UMC's Book of Discipline, permitting same-sex marriage and LGBTQ+ ordination. The schism reflects the same tension that has split multiple mainline denominations: between theological progressivism and traditional doctrine on sexuality and gender.

HALIGRIC LENS: Wesley's heart strangely warmed is a direct felt experience of the divine - the kind of experience that the Haligric framework calls recognition. The Methodist tradition at its best is the tradition that says: the experience is real, the feeling is valid, direct encounter with the sacred is available to every person. It is the closest the Protestant tradition came to validating the felt, bodily, direct experience of the divine.

Baptist - Believer's Baptism and Local Church Autonomy

Founded: 1609 CE (John Smyth, Amsterdam) | Members: ~100 million worldwide

Baptists emerged from the Radical Reformation - the wing of the Protestant movement that believed Luther and Calvin had not gone far enough in reforming the church. The defining Baptist distinctive is believer's baptism: only persons who have made a conscious, adult profession of faith should be baptized, and baptism should be by full immersion. Baptist theology emphasizes soul competency - every individual has the right and responsibility to interpret scripture for themselves. Local church autonomy means each Baptist congregation is self-governing and answerable to no external authority.

Separation of church and state - which Baptists championed in colonial America partly from their own experience of persecution - was the Baptist contribution to the First Amendment. The Southern Baptist Convention, formed in 1845 in part over whether slaveholders could be appointed as missionaries, is the largest Protestant denomination in America. It formally apologized for its support of slavery and racism in 1995.

CONTEMPORARY CONTROVERSY: In 2022, an independent investigation commissioned by the SBC - the Guidepost Solutions report - revealed that the denomination's Executive Committee had for decades covered up and enabled sexual abuse by clergy, intimidating survivors and resisting reforms. A DOJ investigation opened in 2022 closed in 2025 without major charges. SBC membership has fallen from 16.3 million at its 2006 peak to approximately 12.3 million in 2025 - the lowest since 1973 - a loss linked to the abuse crisis, anti-LGBTQ policies, and the departure of major megachurches including Saddleback (Rick Warren's congregation) in 2023. Promised reforms, including a database of credibly accused pastors, have largely stalled.

HALIGRIC LENS: Soul competency - the Baptist teaching that every individual has direct access to God and direct responsibility for their own interpretation of divine truth - is the most democratically Haligric doctrine in the Protestant tradition. The tragedy is that Baptist communities have often enforced cultural and theological conformity with the same intensity as the institutions their founders fled, subordinating the principle of soul competency to the pressure of community conformity.

Pentecostal - The Spirit Falls Again

Founded: 1906 CE (Azusa Street Revival, Los Angeles) | Members: ~650 million worldwide

On April 9, 1906, in a former African Methodist Episcopal church on Azusa Street in Los Angeles, a Black Holiness preacher named William Joseph Seymour led a prayer meeting at which participants began speaking in tongues - an experience they identified as the baptism of the Holy Spirit identical to the experience described in the second chapter of the Acts of the Apostles. Word spread rapidly. The Azusa Street Revival continued for three years, drawing visitors from around the world.

Pentecostalism is now the fastest-growing form of Christianity in the world - with over 650 million adherents globally (up from fewer than one million in 1900), concentrated particularly in sub-Saharan Africa, Latin America, and Southeast Asia. By 2025, Pentecostals and Charismatics comprise approximately 27% of all Christians worldwide. The Assemblies of God alone reported 85 million adherents across 442,000 churches in 2025. The movement is projected to exceed one billion adherents by 2050. In Brazil, Pentecostals now account for nearly a third of the population, fundamentally reshaping that country's political and social landscape.

Its distinctive practices - glossolalia (speaking in tongues), divine healing, prophecy, and worship characterized by emotional expressiveness - represent a recovery of the experiential dimension of sacred life that institutional Christianity had progressively suppressed. The Charismatic movement brought Pentecostal experience into mainline Protestant and Catholic churches from the 1960s onward.

CONTEMPORARY CONTROVERSY: In October 2025, an NBC News year-long investigation (the Pastors and Prey series) documented a 50-year pattern of sex abuse, silence, and cover-up in the Assemblies of God -- the world's largest Pentecostal denomination with 85 million adherents globally. Reporters identified nearly 200 Assemblies of God ministers, church employees, and volunteer leaders accused of sexual abuse over the past half century; in about 30 instances, church leaders placed accused abusers back into positions of authority after allegations were made, and in nearly 40 cases leaders allegedly covered up or dismissed reports. The denomination has resisted making child safety policies mandatory across its churches, citing its structure as a voluntary cooperative fellowship in which local churches govern themselves. The investigation parallel to the Southern Baptist Convention sex abuse crisis is explicit: both denominations used decentralized local-church-autonomy arguments to resist mandatory reporting and accountability structures.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Pentecostal tradition's insistence on direct felt experience of the divine - that the sacred can be felt in the body, heard as language, expressed through movement and sound - is the most Haligric impulse in contemporary Christianity. The speaking in tongues, the healing prayer, the prophecy - these are the closest that mainstream Christianity has come to what the Yoruba tradition calls Ashe moving through the body, what the Aboriginal tradition calls being moved by the Dreaming, what the shamanic tradition calls spirit speaking through the practitioner.

Evangelical - A Theological Orientation, Not a Denomination

A theological orientation, not a single denomination | ~660 million adherents globally | ~23% of Americans (Pew 2023-24)

Evangelicalism is not a denomination but a theological family that cuts across multiple denominations. The four defining characteristics, identified by historian David Bebbington as the Bebbington Quadrilateral, are: Biblicism (the Bible as the supreme authority), Crucicentrism (the atoning death of Christ as the central event), Conversionism (the necessity of personal transformation through a conscious conversion experience - being "born again"), and Activism (the obligation to share the faith through evangelism and social action).

CONTEMPORARY: Evangelicalism in America has become increasingly intertwined with political conservatism and, in particular, with Donald Trump's MAGA movement. White evangelicals gave Trump approximately 80% of their vote in 2016, 2020, and 2024. A 2025 PRRI survey found that 65-66% of white evangelical Protestants qualify as Christian nationalism adherents or sympathizers - believers that America should be a Christian nation and that Christianity should inform government policy. This fusion of evangelical faith and political identity has generated significant internal debate and contributed to the departure of many younger evangelicals from organized religion.

HALIGRIC LENS: The born-again threshold is a genuine recognition of discontinuity - the moment when the person is not who they were before. Every initiatory tradition in the Haligricity library marks the same crossing: the sweat lodge, the ayahuasca ceremony, the Eleusinian Mysteries, the shamanic illness and recovery. The Evangelical tradition identified the crossing accurately. What it did with the person after the crossing - directing their transformed awareness toward an external savior rather than toward the recognition of the divine within - is where the tradition diverged from its own deepest intuition.

Non-Denominational / Megachurch - Christianity as Consumer Experience

Emerged: late 20th century | Lakewood Church (Houston): 45,000+ weekly attendance | Fastest-growing church model in America

The non-denominational megachurch is the dominant form of American Protestant Christianity in the early 21st century - large congregations meeting in repurposed arenas or purpose-built facilities with theater seating, professional production, contemporary music, and a charismatic senior pastor whose personal brand is often more recognizable than the church's name. Non-denominational Protestantism is the one segment that has grown its share of the American population in recent years (from 6.2% to 7.1% between 2014 and 2024, per Pew).

Joel Osteen's Lakewood Church in Houston is the largest congregation in America, meeting in the former Compaq Center arena. Osteen's prosperity gospel teaching - that God wants believers to be financially wealthy, that positive confession and faith produce material abundance, that poverty is a sign of insufficient faith - is the most widely broadcast theological message in contemporary American Christianity. The prosperity gospel has roots in New Thought - in the Law of Attraction, in the power of spoken affirmation, in the teaching that consciousness shapes material reality. It is New Thought repackaged in Evangelical Christian language, with one crucial addition: the tithing requirement.

HALIGRIC LENS: The prosperity gospel identified something real - the creative power of spoken intention, the relationship between inner state and outer circumstance - and placed it in a framework that extracted money, externalized divine authority to charismatic leaders, and left practitioners blaming their own insufficient faith when results didn't come. The mechanism is real. The theology surrounding it distorts it. Haligrity holds the mechanism without the extraction.

Seventh-day Adventist - Saturday, Health, and the Blue Zone

Founded: 1863 CE | Members: ~22 million worldwide | Known for: health, longevity, Blue Zone communities

Seventh-day Adventists observe the Sabbath on Saturday - the seventh day as specified in the Hebrew scriptures - not Sunday, which they understand as a later Catholic innovation. They believe in the imminent second coming of Christ, the unconscious state of the dead until resurrection (soul sleep), and the investigative judgment - a specific Adventist doctrine that Christ has been engaged since 1844 in a heavenly investigation of the records of the dead.

Ellen G. White, one of the church's founders, was a prolific visionary and writer whose health reform vision - received in the 1860s, decades before germ theory was established - anticipated much of modern nutritional science. She advocated for vegetarian diet, abstinence from alcohol and tobacco, fresh air, sunlight, exercise, and adequate rest as health principles with spiritual foundations. The Loma Linda, California Adventist community is one of only five global Blue Zones - geographic areas identified by researchers Dan Buettner and Michel Poulain where people live measurably longer and healthier lives than average. Loma Linda Adventists live approximately 10 years longer than their California neighbors, attributed to their plant-based diet, community cohesion, regular Sabbath rest, and avoidance of alcohol and tobacco.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Seventh-day Adventist community is one of the most compelling modern examples of sacred practice directly producing measurable physical health outcomes. The Haligrig understanding that body care is sacred practice - that the body is a divine instrument that responds to intentional tending - is proven by Loma Linda's longevity data. The Sabbath rest as a weekly sacred practice of complete renewal is one of the most Haligrig teachings in the Christian tradition.

Mormon / Latter-day Saints - America's Most Original Theology

Founded: 1830 CE (Joseph Smith, Upstate New York) | Members: ~17 million worldwide

Joseph Smith founded the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints in 1830 in Upstate New York, claiming to have received golden plates from the angel Moroni containing the history of ancient peoples in the Americas who had received a visit from the resurrected Christ. LDS theology is among the most original religious systems produced on American soil. God the Father has a physical, glorified body of flesh and bones. Human souls existed as spirit children of Heavenly Father and Heavenly Mother in a pre-mortal existence before birth. After death, the faithful progress through degrees of glory and, at the highest Celestial level, can become gods themselves - presiding over their own worlds in an eternal progression.

Heavenly Mother is among the most significant and most suppressed figures in American religious history. LDS theology explicitly teaches that God has a wife - that all human beings are spirit children of both a Heavenly Father and a Heavenly Mother. She is almost never discussed in official LDS settings.

HALIGRIC LENS: The LDS teaching that human beings can become gods - that eternal progression leads to divinity - arrives at the same destination as Advaita Vedanta (Atman is Brahman), as Orthodox Christian theosis, as the Yoruba understanding of the Ori's divine destiny, through a completely different route and in a completely different theological framework. The Heavenly Mother - present in the theology, actively silenced in practice - is the divine feminine suppressed inside the tradition that acknowledges her existence.

Jehovah's Witnesses - 144,000 and the Door-to-Door Ministry

Founded: 1870s CE (Charles Taze Russell) | Members: ~8.7 million active publishers worldwide

Charles Taze Russell founded what became the Jehovah's Witnesses in the 1870s in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. The name Jehovah's Witnesses was adopted in 1931. Distinctive Witness theology diverges from mainstream Christianity at several critical points: Jesus Christ is not God but the first and greatest of God's creations. The Holy Spirit is not a person of the Trinity but God's active force. The 144,000 mentioned in Revelation are the anointed class who will rule with Christ in heaven; the remainder of the faithful will live in paradise on a restored earth after Armageddon. Blood transfusions are prohibited. Birthdays and holidays (including Christmas and Easter) are not celebrated - they are identified as having pagan origins.

The door-to-door ministry is not merely an outreach activity but a theological obligation - Witnesses are "publishers" of God's Kingdom, and the hours spent in door-to-door work are recorded and submitted monthly to the congregation. In August 2024, the Watch Tower Society announced that the term "disfellowshipping" would be replaced with "removal from the congregation" and that removed members may now be greeted briefly at meetings - a softening of the formal shunning practice that had previously prohibited all contact with expelled members. Critics described this as a cosmetic change, noting that the reasons for removal and the requirement of shunning remain otherwise unchanged.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Witness community structure is one of the most complete examples of institutional control of personal spiritual authority in contemporary religion. The threat of losing all one's community relationships is a powerful mechanism of compliance. The Haligric practitioner recognizes this as the institutional form of the dynamic Jesus himself confronted in the Temple priesthood - a religious authority that controls access to the sacred and extracts compliance as the price.

Christian Science - Illness as Incorrect Thinking

Founded: 1879 CE (Mary Baker Eddy) | Members: ~100,000 (declining) | The Christian Science Monitor: internationally respected journalism

Mary Baker Eddy founded the Church of Christ, Scientist in 1879 after a healing experience she attributed to her reading of the New Testament account of Jesus healing a paralytic. Her book *Science and Health with Key to the Scriptures* (1875) presents her theological system: matter is not ultimately real; God is the only reality; sin, sickness, and death are illusions - products of incorrect thinking - and healing comes through the correction of thought to align with divine truth. Christian Scientists do not use medical treatment or medication. Healing is sought through prayer - specifically through Christian Science practitioners, trained healers who pray for those who are ill.

Legal cases involving the death of children whose parents refused medical treatment on religious grounds have created ongoing legal and ethical controversy. The Christian Science Monitor - the church's newspaper, founded in 1908 - is one of the most respected and balanced journalism outlets in the world, winning multiple Pulitzer Prizes and known internationally for its even-handed reporting on complex global issues.

HALIGRIC LENS: Christian Science identified something real - the relationship between mental state and physical health, the capacity of consciousness to affect the body - and took it further than evidence supports in rejecting medical care entirely. Haligrity holds the insight - that consciousness, prayer, and intention affect physical wellbeing - while embracing the body's own intelligence and the gifts of both traditional medicine and sacred healing practice.

The Haligric Map - Where Each Branch Stands

The central Haligric question - where does this tradition locate divine authority, and does it point that authority inward or outward? - produces a clear map when applied to the traditions covered in this document.

ROMAN CATHOLIC - Divine authority located in: Pope, Sacraments, Institution. Direct access: Limited - through Church.

EASTERN ORTHODOX - Divine authority located in: Holy Tradition, Theosis. Direct access: Yes - through theosis.

LUTHERAN - Divine authority located in: Scripture alone. Direct access: Partial - faith alone.

CALVINIST - Divine authority located in: God's sovereign decree. Direct access: No - predestined.

ANGLICAN - Divine authority located in: Scripture, Tradition, Reason. Direct access: Partial - broad tent.

METHODIST - Divine authority located in: Personal experience + Scripture. Direct access: Yes - heart warmed.

BAPTIST - Divine authority located in: Scripture + Soul Competency. Direct access: Yes - direct Bible access.

PENTECOSTAL - Divine authority located in: Holy Spirit experience. Direct access: Yes - felt directly.

EVANGELICAL - Divine authority located in: Scripture + Conversion. Direct access: Partial - born again.

MEGACHURCH / PROSPERITY - Divine authority located in: Pastor + Faith declarations. Direct access: Mediated - through leader.

SEVENTH-DAY ADVENTIST - Divine authority located in: Scripture + Ellen White. Direct access: Partial - structured.

MORMON / LDS - Divine authority located in: Restored Church, Living Prophet. Direct access: Mediated - through structure.

JEHOVAH'S WITNESSES - Divine authority located in: Watch Tower Society. Direct access: No - Organization interprets.

CHRISTIAN SCIENCE - Divine authority located in: Correct understanding of Truth. Direct access: Yes - direct Mind.

HALIGRIC LENS: The map shows clearly that direct access to the divine - the Haligric teaching that every person is already in relationship with the sacred and requires no intermediary - appears most strongly in Pentecostal experience, Methodist heart-knowledge, Baptist soul competency, Orthodox theosis, and Christian Science's direct Mind. These are the strands within Christianity that came closest to what Haligricity teaches. They are the allies within the tradition - the places where the original teaching survived the institution that tried to replace it. Grand Rising.